

TELANGANA

The Red REVOLT

The rebellion by the farmers of the princely state of Hyderabad not only ensured land reforms but also aided in the unification of the region with India

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

Visit any village deep in the dusty drylands of Telengana and encounter an unlettered elder. The instant greeting of submissive welcome will be "I am your slave." This is the last remaining psychological scar of an insurrection that took place during the mid-'40s. The armed struggle against the feudal landlords—the *jagirdars* and *deshmukhs*—in the princely state of Hyderabad with exactions and forced labour, called *vetti-chakiri*, was responsible for the peasant uprising not only against the feudal landlords but also against the Nizam of Hyderabad himself.

The worst forms of exploitation followed by the landlords provided ideal conditions for an armed rebellion led by the communists with the slogan "land for the tiller". One of the most supociferous demands of the movement

was waiving the debts of the peasants. The revolt in Telangana was sparked by the murder of Doddi Komarayya, a worker of the nascent nationalist movement called the Andhra Maha Sabha (AMS), in July 1946. The struggle took place at a time when the Nizam was trying to resist the efforts of the Indian government to merge his state with the Indian union. The attacks by the Nizam's police on the communists and the resultant counterattacks led to a ban on the Communist Party on December 3 that year. The *Razakars*—the newly formed fundamentalist militia of the Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen—joined the Nizam's army and the police in suppressing the peasantry.

SARDAR PATEL, deputy prime minister, 1948

"If Hyderabad does not see the writing on the wall, it goes the way Junagadh has gone."

UP IN ARMS:
Peasants get organised

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